DAILY READING • 样张

Eight Degrees

2026-11-10 · 当天 50 词全部覆盖 · 全文 608 词 · 5 段

短文

Callum had worked in the fermentation lab for four years, and he still derived most of his pleasure from a cloudy culture. His passion was never the theory but the bench itself, the warm wort and the vertical row of jars. In spite of the long nights, he had never wanted to leave. Then the old freezer failed again, and that breakdown left forty samples at room temperature until morning. The spare cord was too short to reach the socket, so the tubes waited in a borrowed cooler. Dr. Hale, who had counseled him through two ruined batches, asked for a definite figure for the lost hours. He promised to refine his notes before the weekly engagement with the partners, though that meeting had never felt so heavy.

Rebuilding the lost data took three days, and the work was a steady drain on his patience. The first phase was simple, because he only had to expand the table from twelve rows to thirty and let the software filter the outliers. Numbers, he knew, tend to drift when a machine warms up, so the slow rise in the readings did not alarm him at first. Then a single lump of points sat well above the rest, and the whole curve began to float upward from November onward. The freezer's temperature attachment had been recording all along, and its log was a flat line at eight degrees. When he alerted Dr. Hale, she read the file twice and said nothing for a long moment.

His co-author Pfaff did not share that viewpoint, and said so over coffee in the corridor. Pfaff argued that the central proposition of the paper still held, and that no review panel would question a curve built on three years. Callum did the detective work himself, matching timestamps until six rows proved to be copies of a later run. On any fair interpretation those figures were duplicates, and duplicating them would render the whole section worthless. The validity of three years of work rested on a log that showed eight degrees all winter. For a week Pfaff exerted a quiet pressure at lunch, and Callum began to wonder what he was liable to lose. Before the weekend Pfaff gave an admission that surprised them both.

Meanwhile the department needed a five-minute film for the open day, and the script fell to Callum because his writing was clearer than anyone else's. He filmed the culture room, the

incubator, and one species of salt-tolerant yeast that the lab had specialized in for a decade. Good science, he told the camera, is a discipline of small habits repeated without applause. The old technician wheeled a cart past the door with a new brand of reagent on it and asked whether the payment for his extra hours would come as coffee. Callum could furnish the original notebooks within an hour, but he had only one option left.

Pfaff, once his closest ally and lately his only real opponent, was absent from the Friday meeting. The numbers came out of the draft, the claim shrank until it was realistic, and the drop in the headline figure was dramatic enough to be honest. Callum had expected a hollow victory, yet the room felt lighter afterwards. He laced the report with one dry joke about freezer doors and then thrust the tray of fresh plates onto the bench. The repeat run would take six weeks, and he began it with an energetic patience that surprised the students. The lab would strive to finish before spring, and on the last page he wrote a line his grandmother used to pray over.

解析 · 行间留白，可直接手写

Callum had worked in the fermentation lab for four years, and he still derived most of his pleasure from a cloudy culture. His passion was never the theory but the bench itself, the warm wort and the vertical row of jars. **In spite of** the long nights, he had never wanted to leave. Then the old freezer failed again, and that breakdown left forty samples at room temperature until morning. The spare cord was too short to reach the socket, so the tubes waited in a borrowed cooler. Dr. Hale, who had **counseled him through** two ruined batches, asked for **a definite figure** for the lost hours. He promised to refine his notes before the weekly engagement with the partners, though that meeting had never felt so heavy.

> **In spite of** 尽管，不顾 介词短语，后接名词或动名词，不能接完整句子；比 although 更书面，且不能与 but 连用
> **counseled him through** 陪他熬过（难关）并给建议 counsel sb through sth：counsel 作动词时先接人，再跟 through + 困难，强调持续的专业劝告，比 advise 更正式
> **a definite figure** 确切的数字 definite 修饰可数名词，强调“明确、不含糊”，常与 figure / answer / plan 搭配

Rebuilding the lost data took three days, and the work was **a steady drain on** his patience. The first phase was simple, because he only had to expand the table from twelve rows to thirty and let the software filter the outliers. Numbers, he knew, **tend to drift** when a machine warms up, so the slow rise in the readings did not alarm him at first. Then **a single lump of** points sat well above the rest, and the whole curve began to float upward from November onward. The freezer's temperature attachment had been recording all along, and its log was a flat line at eight degrees. When he alerted Dr. Hale, she read the file twice and said nothing for a long moment.

> **a steady drain on** 对…的持续消耗 drain 作名词时用 a drain on + 资源或精力（patience / funds / energy），不用 drain of
> **tend to drift** 往往会缓慢偏移 tend to + 动词原形，表示一般倾向；后接 drift 这类渐变动词，正好点出“不是突然出错”
> **a single lump of** 单独一簇（集中的一团） lump 指无定形的一团、一块，可数；说数据点时用它比 group 更形象，常与 of + 复数名词连用

His co-author Pfaff did not **share that viewpoint**, and said so over coffee in the corridor. Pfaff argued that **the central proposition** of the paper still held, and that no review panel would question a curve built on three years. Callum did the detective work himself, matching timestamps until six rows proved to be copies of a later run. On any fair interpretation those figures were duplicates, and duplicating them would render the whole section worthless. The validity of three years of work rested on a log that showed eight degrees all winter. For a week Pfaff exerted a quiet pressure at lunch, and Callum began to wonder what he was **liable to lose**. Before the weekend Pfaff gave an admission that surprised them both.

> **share that viewpoint** 认同那个看法 share + 观点类名词（viewpoint / view / opinion），表示“持相同看法”；否定用 not share
> **the central proposition** 核心主张 proposition 指待论证的主张，比 idea 更强调可被质疑；论文、辩论里常用 central / main 修饰
> **liable to lose** 很可能失去 liable to + 动词原形，多指不利后果；与 likely to 近义，但liable 更强调“有风险”

Meanwhile the department needed a five-minute film for the open day, and the script fell to Callum because his writing was clearer than anyone else's. He filmed the culture room, the incubator, and one species of salt-tolerant yeast that the lab had **specialized in** for a decade. Good science, he told the camera, is **a discipline of** small habits repeated without applause. The old technician wheeled a cart past the door with a new brand of reagent on it and asked whether the payment for his extra hours would come as coffee. Callum could **furnish the original notebooks** within an hour, but he had only one option left.

> **specialized in** 专攻，专门从事 specialize in + 领域名词，介词固定用 in；名词形式是 speciality / specialty
> **a discipline of** 一门…的学科 / 一种…的修为 discipline 指有系统的学科，也可指自律；of 后接其核心内容或习惯
> **furnish the original notebooks** 提供原始记录本 furnish 意为“供应、提供”，多接资料、证据、家具等实物，常见于 furnish evidence / records

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> **a hollow victory** 空洞的胜利 hollow 修饰抽象名词时表示“没有实质内容”，固定搭配还有 hollow promise / hollow words
> **laced the report with** 在报告里掺入 lace sth with sth：本义“给…加花边、加酒”，引申为“掺入某种成分”，多用于言辞、食物
> **strive to** 力争做到 strive to + 动词原形，比 try 更正式，强调付出持续努力；过去式 strove 或 strived

译文

卡勒姆在发酵实验室干了四年，至今仍能从一团变浑的菌液里得到大部分乐趣。他热爱的从来不是理论，而是实验台本身：温热的麦芽汁，还有架子上那排竖直摆放的罐子。尽管长夜难熬，他也从没想过离开。后来那台老冰箱又坏了，四十个样本在室温下放到了第二天早上。备用机的电源线太短，够不到插座，试管只好搁在一台借来的冷藏箱里。黑尔博士曾陪他熬过两批全毁的样本，这次她要一个确切的数字，算清损失了多少小时。他答应在每周与资助方的例会前把记录整理得更精确，而那次会面从未显得如此沉重。

重建丢失的数据花了三天，这件事对他的耐心是持续的消耗。第一阶段很简单，他只需把表格从十二行扩到三十行，再让软件过滤掉异常值。他知道机器升温时读数往往会缓慢漂移，所以曲线刚开始往上走时并没有惊动他。可随后有一簇点高高悬在其余点之上，整条曲线从十一月起开始整体上浮。冰箱的温度附件其实一直在记录，日志却是恒温八度的一条直线。他把这事提醒给黑尔博士时，她把文件读了两遍，很久没有说话。

他的合作者普法夫并不认同这个看法，在走廊喝咖啡时当面说了出来。普法夫认为论文的核心主张依然成立，也不会有哪个评审小组去质疑一条建立在三年工作之上的曲线。卡勒姆自己做了这趟侦探活，逐一比对时间戳，直到查出六行其实是后一次运行的复制品。按任何公正的解读，那些数字都是重复值，而重复会让整节内容变得毫无价值。三年工作的有效性，竟系在一条整个冬天都显示八度的日志上。有一周时间，普法夫在午饭时施加着无声的压力，卡勒姆开始怀疑自己可能失去的远不止一个合作者。周末之前，普法夫给出了一个让两人都意外的承认。

与此同时，系里需要一部五分钟的开放日短片，剧本落到卡勒姆头上，因为他的文字比谁都清楚。他拍了培养室、培养箱，还有一种耐盐酵母——实验室专攻它已有十年。好的科学，他对着镜头说，是一门把细小习惯重复下去、无人喝彩的学科。老技师推着手推车从门口经过，车上放着一个新品牌的试剂，还问他加班费能不能用咖啡抵。卡勒姆一小时内就能拿出原始记录本，可他只剩一个选择。

普法夫曾是他最亲近的盟友，近来却成了他唯一的对手，这次周五的会他没有到场。那些数字从稿子里撤了下来，结论缩到切合实际的范围，头条数字的下降幅度足够明显，也足够诚实。卡勒姆原以为会是一场空洞的胜利，可屋子反而轻了。他在报告里掺进一句关于冰箱门的冷笑话，然后把一盘新培养皿推向实验台。重复实验要六周，他带着一种让学生意外的、精力充沛的耐心开始了。实验室会力争在春天前做完，而在最后一页，他写下一句祖母从前常替他祈祷的话。